一颗棉花糖的真相

The Truth About One Marshmallow



一颗棉花糖能预测孩子的未来吗?

READ 纯净阅读

CHECK 中文核对

LEARN 词汇记忆

RECALL 回想巩固

英文原文

Picture a nursery school on Stanford's campus in the late 1960s and early 1970s. A child of about four or five sits in solitude before one treat, facing a blunt bargain: eat it now, or resist temptation for about 15 minutes and earn two. Impulsive children often surrender instantly; resolute ones hold out.

Follow-ups made the test legendary. A 1990 study in Developmental Psychology found that, as adolescents, longer waiters tended to attain higher scores on the SAT, a US college-entrance exam. A trivial snack became an emblem of virtue, and restraint at four was glorified as a predictor of destiny.

Yet the foundation was precarious. Only a few dozen children entered the SAT analysis, predominantly the sons and daughters of Stanford faculty and postgraduate students. Such a homogeneous, privileged group could scarcely represent ordinary families, and prosperous homes may foster patience and academic success alike.

A study published in Psychological Science in May 2018 ran a conceptual replication: the same idea, a new sample, modified methods. More than 900 youngsters from diverse backgrounds were assessed at four and a half and again at 15. The raw link was roughly half as strong as the original finding. Adjusting for family background and early cognitive ability shrank it by about two thirds, leaving most estimates statistically insignificant.

The test is not worthless; it may still reflect something substantive. Research published in Cognition in January 2013 adds context: children whose trust an adult had just betrayed waited markedly less than peers dealing with a reliable adult. How long a child perseveres depends partly on how trustworthy the adults around them seem.

中文译文

想象一下20世纪60年代末至70年代初，斯坦福大学校园里的一所幼儿园。一个四五岁的孩子独自坐在一份零食前，面对一个直截了当的选择：现在吃掉它，或者抵住诱惑，等上约15分钟，就能得到两份。冲动的孩子往往马上放弃等待，意志坚定的孩子则坚持下去。

后续追踪研究让这项测验广为人知。1990年发表于《发展心理学》的一项研究发现，进入青少年时期后，当初等得更久的孩子，往往在美国大学入学考试SAT中取得更高分数。一份不起眼的零食成了美德的象征，四岁时表现出的克制，也被过分推崇为预测人生走向的指标。

然而，这一结论的基础并不牢靠。进入SAT成绩分析的孩子只有几十名，而且主要是斯坦福大学教师和研究生的子女。这样一个背景相似、条件优越的群体，很难代表普通家庭。富裕的家庭环境，也可能同时有助于培养耐心和取得学业成功。

2018年5月发表于《心理科学》的一项研究进行了概念性重复实验：沿用同一研究思路，换用新的样本，并调整研究方法。研究者对来自不同背景的900多名儿童，在四岁半和15岁时分别进行了评估。未经调整的关联强度，大约只有早期研究结果的一半；进一步控制家庭背景和早期认知能力的影响后，这种关联又缩小了约三分之二，大多数估计结果都未达到统计显著性。

这项测验并非毫无价值，它或许仍能反映一些有实质意义的信息。2013年1月发表于《认知》的一项研究补充了背景：刚刚遭遇成年人失信的孩子，等待时间明显短于与守信成年人相处的同龄人。孩子能坚持多久，部分取决于他们觉得身边的大人有多可信。

“统计上不显著”不等于已经证明不存在关联；这里强调，计入背景差异后，早期结论的支持力度明显减弱。

核心词汇

先记这22项。连着下方的原文短语一起回想。

resist v.
抵挡；忍住
resist temptation

temptation n.
诱惑
resist temptation for about 15 minutes

impulsive adj.
冲动的
Impulsive children often surrender

surrender v.
放弃抵抗；屈服
often surrender instantly;

resolute adj.
意志坚定的
resolute ones hold out.

hold out phr. v.
坚持下去
resolute ones hold out.

legendary adj.
广为传颂的；著名的
Follow-ups made the test legendary.

restraint n.
克制；自制
restraint at four was glorified

glorify v.
过分美化；推崇
glorified as a predictor of destiny

predictor n.
预测因素；预测指标
a predictor of destiny.

precarious adj.
不稳固的；不可靠的
Yet the foundation was precarious.

homogeneous adj.
同质的；背景相似的
a homogeneous, privileged group

privileged adj.
享有优越条件的
a homogeneous, privileged group

foster v.
培养；促进
foster patience and academic success

replication n.
重复研究；重复实验
ran a conceptual replication:

diverse adj.
多种多样的
from diverse backgrounds

assess v.
评估
were assessed at four and a half

adjust for phr. v.
控制……的影响
Adjusting for family background

cognitive adj.
认知的
early cognitive ability

insignificant adj.
未达统计显著性的
statistically insignificant.

betray v.
辜负；背弃
trust an adult had just betrayed

trustworthy adj.
可信赖的
how trustworthy the adults around them

文中词汇与搭配

补充词汇共38项。保留每个表达在本文中的意思。

nursery school n.
幼儿园

campus n.
大学校园

in solitude phr.
独自；独处地

blunt adj.
直截了当的

bargain n.
交易；约定的条件

earn v.
挣得；赢得

instantly adv.
立即；马上

follow-up n.
后续追踪研究

adolescent n.
青少年

attain v.
达到；取得

trivial adj.
微不足道的

snack n.
零食

emblem n.
象征；标志

virtue n.
美德

destiny n.
命运；人生走向

foundation n.
（结论的）基础

a few dozen phr.
几十个

predominantly adv.
主要地；大多

faculty n.
大学全体教员

文中词汇与搭配 续

补充词汇共38项。保留每个表达在本文中的意思。

postgraduate adj.
研究生的

scarcely adv.
几乎不

ordinary adj.
普通的

prosperous adj.
富裕的

alike adv.
同样地；两者都

conceptual adj.
概念层面的

modified adj.
调整过的；改动过的

youngster n.
儿童；少年

link n.
关联；联系

statistically adv.
在统计学上

worthless adj.
毫无价值的

reflect v.
反映

substantive adj.
有实质意义的

context n.
背景；具体情境

markedly adv.
明显地

peer n.
同龄人

persevere v.
坚持；不放弃

depend v.
取决于（常与on连用）

on prep.
与depend连用，表示取决于

回想与回顾

先遮住下方答案，再把四个词放回原文。

01 Impulsive children often surrender instantly; _____ ones hold out.

02 Yet the foundation was _____.

03 Adjusting for family background and early cognitive ability shrank it by about two thirds, leaving most estimates statistically _____.

04 How long a child perseveres depends partly on how _____ the adults around them seem.

文章主线

- 选择 四五岁孩子可立刻吃一份零食，或等约15分钟换两份，用来观察延迟满足。
- 走红 早期追踪发现，等得久的孩子后来SAT（美国大学入学考试）成绩较高，测验遂被当作成功预测器。
- 局限 早期SAT分析仅数十名孩子，且多来自优裕家庭；家庭条件可能同时影响耐心与成绩。
- 复核 2018年复核900多名不同背景儿童；计入家庭背景与早期认知差异后，关联大幅减弱，多数估计不具统计显著性。
- 关键 另一实验发现，刚遇到不守信大人的孩子等得更短；等待也反映信任，不能据此断定一个人的命运。

参考答案　1 resolute 2 precarious 3 insignificant 4 trustworthy